The Ethics of Artificial Intelligence

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Artificial Intelligence is a rapidly growing tool that is being utilized in a plethora of different ways. AI has also become an extremely heated ethical debate within many different circles, including those of Computer Scientists. I personally am a Computer Science major, and the Computer Science field has been thrust into a new world of technology with AI and has been grasping how to properly handle its existence ethically. Allowing machines to act more autonomously can be considered a serious moral issue to some people, as they believe that it is removing from the average man or woman the capacity to think for themselves. Some would also argue that it is unethical to use AI in computer fields, as often Computer Science jobs will involve the handling of private and personal data, and the idea of that data being held only by a machine learning system is worrying to some. There are many ways to try and understand how these issues are would be ethical dilemmas, and applying different viewpoints such as the Penn State Ethical Analysis Method or a Christian worldview can significantly help a person put into perspective the ethical dilemma of Artificial Intelligence.

AI's Impact on Computer Science

Artificial Intelligence is defined as a machine's ability to simulate human thought, creativity, or even solve problems that would often require a human perspective to think through. As one can imagine, this development has severely shaped the way Computer Science is approached as a whole. Artificial intelligence is often used in Computer Science for automating processes and creating new and faster ways to analyze data (Stryker, 2024). While this sounds like a harmless tool that is used to speed up developmental processes, there are also risks involved with the use of Artificial Intelligence. These issues include risks of corrupted

data sets their learning was based off, or even a cyberattack on that data set to alter the machines' learning process (Stryker, 2025). The ethical boundaries on Artificial Intelligence have become blurred because of its usage, and as such it is often unclear where lines should be drawn on the subject.

Artificial intelligence has become synonymous with different ethical issues, including job displacement. Companies often want to automate systems whenever they can, and currently, some entry level positions are being shelved for artificial intelligence, as some software companies are rushing to automate and modernize their systems (Forbes, 2024). Data Privacy is also extremely important to consider when thinking about the ethical and unethical use of artificial intelligence, as letting a machine protect sensitive data instead of human created systems can easily lead to issues about how the data is surveyed and handled, leaving the ethics of the situation ambiguous. If these issues are left unaddressed, then the usage of artificial intelligence runs at the risk of becoming fully unethical.

Ethical Analysis

There are many different frameworks to apply different ethical issues to. One of them being the Penn State Ethical Analysis. This methodology gives us a way to compare and understand different ethical issues involving technology and determine the most ethical and appropriate course of action (Penn State, n.d). The first process is identifying the problem, and then begin gathering information. The problem is, at its core, the potential ethical caveats of allowing a machine-learned system to handle private information. There is tension between the people creating this technology to further its usage in more situations, and the people who use the technology who worry about it getting out of control with the handling of sensitive data. In

other words, the pursuit of progress can be at odds with a human need for transparency. Another issue is how some entry level job opportunities are being potentially outsourced to artificial intelligence. The next steps are to apply guiding principles and then take action. If the main issue is a need for humans to know how their data is being handled by artificial intelligence, then a great way to find an ethical solution would be to create job opportunities to oversee and personally handle a company's usage of artificial intelligence. This would solve the issue of transparency, since humans would still be handling data at the end of the day, and it would also open new opportunities in computer science fields for new work.

Another perspective that should be considered is the Christian worldview. The Bible is a wonderful tool for ethical frameworks, and is helpful in any ethical situation, including AI. Christians must use technology is a way that is honoring to God. Micha 6:8 commands Christians to “act justly, and to love mercy, and to walk humbly with your God.” Similar to this verse, Matthew 22:39 tells us to “Love your neighbor as you love yourself.” From these two verses, we can deduce that artificial intelligence should be used with the mindset of putting people first. Artificial intelligence should not be used to exploit or harm other people, but rather it should be used to uplift and protect people. As computer scientists, we bear the responsibility to keep artificial intelligence as servant minded as possible. People's lives should not be run by artificial intelligence, but rather they should be able to use artificial intelligence to benefit themselves and others. The Christian ethical view focuses more on the character of the people who utilize the tool, rather than the tool itself.

When thinking about computer ethics, the most notable of all frameworks are the Association for Computer Machinery code of ethics, and the Institute of Electricians and

Electronics Engineers code of ethics. The ACM code of ethics provides a strong emphasis on being a tool to help make ethical decisions and notes that “All people are stakeholders in computing” (ACM, n.d) This helps us determine that we should prevent any potential harm to others that could arise through use of artificial intelligence. The IEEE code of ethics places a strong emphasis on fairness to outside users and the safety of mentioned users. The code specifically states that you should “hold paramount the safety, health, and welfare of the public” (IEEE, n.d). Both codes place an emphasis on developers preventing harmful uses of technology, and in terms of artificial intelligence, the codes can be followed to determine that artificial intelligence should be monitored, and boundaries should be set so that full transparency for the user can be achieved, and therefore protecting the people and allowing more trust in developers.

Comparison

Both the Christian and ethical codes share a view of protecting people from harm. They both consider responsibility and honesty, so that newer tools are utilized properly. There are, however, some notable differences between the two. For example, the basis of the ethics codes of ACM and IEEE is that developers and programmers should be professional and should accept responsibility for the usage and monitoring of things like artificial intelligence. These codes are mostly based on societal norms and human level reasoning. The Christian viewpoint on ethics is based on intent, and that developers should act out of love for their users, as that is how they are commanded to approach things by God. Christians should be motived to act ethically not just because of a code, but because of their love and morals. While both views

have separate foundations, they can be used in tandem to make a fully comprehensive understanding of how to approach ethics in technology and computer science.

Conclusion

Artificial intelligence has created new and profound issues and challenges within the realm of computer science. The Penn State Methodology can be used to understand the process of assessing the problem and then taking whatever proper actions are necessary. The Christian view shows us that these issues should be undertaken with a view of love, and it also gives us the idea that we should utilize technology like artificial intelligence for the good of other people, rather than risking harm to them. The ACM and IEEE ethical codes show us that we as programmers should remain professional and fair in our usage and implementation of technology like artificial intelligence. With these views combined, it is clear that artificial intelligence use should not grow to a point where the good of the user is no longer considered. While artificial intelligence is a huge step for technology, it is unethical to use it in a way that could be harmful to the user. Ultimately, full utilization of these ethical principles can help ensure that artificial intelligence remains a tool used for the benefit of people, rather than for harm.

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